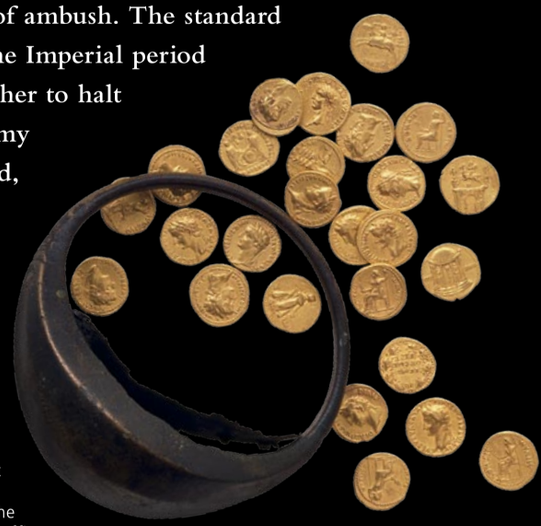
ROMAN WEAPONS AND EQUIPMENT

A legionary on the march not only had to bear the weight of his armour, shield, and weapons, which could be as much as 20kg (44lb), but also had to carry a bulky pack of equipment – ranging from entrenching tools to cooking pots and pans. This could add 15kg (33lb) or more to his total load. Heavier items of kit, such as quern stones to grind corn, were carried by mules or ox-carts. Ideally a number of soldiers would be spared the burden of their full kit so that they would be ready to fight in case of ambush. The standard weapons of an infantryman in the Imperial period were two *pila* (javelins), used either to halt a charge or to soften up the enemy before the Roman forces attacked, and a short sword for fighting at close quarters once battle was joined. Many legionaries also carried a short dagger.



Marching pack
A soldier's kit obviously varied according to the climate and nature of the campaign, but would normally include essential tools for setting up temporary camps and fortifications, as well as a pack holding three days' rations along with his personal effects. Additional items could easily be strapped onto the T-shaped carrying pole.

Short sword
The short, pointed sword *(gladius)* was an effective stabbing weapon for fighting at close quarters from behind shields in well-disciplined ranks. This example, about 70cm (28in) in length, dates from the late 1st century CE and is of the kind shown worn by the legionaries on Trajan's Column. The precise details of the handle, pommel, and blade are based on examples excavated at Pompeii. The blades of later Roman swords were significantly longer.



A soldier's pay
This hoard of gold coins from the period of the Roman invasion of Britain in 43 CE, was found buried in Kent in southeastern England. It was perhaps the savings of one of the invading army – presumably an officer because it represents about four years' pay for an ordinary legionary. Soldiers carried their money in purses like bracelets that could only be opened when taken off the wrist.

> "THEY CARRY … A SAW, A BASKET, A PICK, AND AN AXE, AS WELL AS A LEATHER STRAP, A SICKLE, A CHAIN, AND ENOUGH RATIONS … FOR THREE DAYS. IN FACT, THE INFANTRYMAN CARRIES SO MUCH EQUIPMENT THAT HE IS NOT VERY DIFFERENT FROM A MULE."
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> **FLAVIUS JOSEPHUS,** *THE JEWISH WAR*, 1ST CENTURY CE